ROLE OF THE LEADER IN INJURY AVOIDANCE

WELCOME

Welcome to this British Athletics module – Role of the leader in injury avoidance.

OBJECTIVES

By the end of this module, you should be able to:

- Identify common running injuries and their causes.
- Recognise the role a leader plays in injury avoidance and treating injuries.

COMMON INJURIES

What common running injuries have you heard of?

There are many types of running injuries and you may learn about the most common ones below:

Muscle Injuries:

- A pulled or strained muscle may occur when a muscle is overstretched or torn.
- Sore muscles, especially upper or lower leg may last 24-48 hours after exercise.
- Very tight feeling muscles may be due to not cooling down appropriately, and not stretching properly.
- Cuts and scrapes may occur due to falls or collisions.

Joint Injuries:

- Sprains can be as a result of overstretching or tearing ligaments.
- A dislocation may be caused by sudden trauma on the joint, such as a fall or impact.

Other Types of Injury:

- Bone injury, for example a fracture which is a break or crack of a bone.
- Pain along the front of the shin, may be due to inflammation.
- Pain in the Achilles tendon area may occur after excessive exercise.
- Blisters are caused by friction of socks or shoes.

YOUNG ATHLETES CAUTION

Let's not forget about the risk to young athletes as identified in Energy Systems. For pre-pubescent athletes, the lactate system is under developed and the aerobic system tends to dominate. As it's underdeveloped, younger runners don't fully understand when they're working too hard and we have to protect them from this.

In addition to understanding the energy system implications, there are also other injury risks we should be aware of for young athletes.

- A small 12 year old running alongside an adult will be taking maybe twice as many strides as the adult to keep up.
- This may result in double the impact on developing bones and joints.

Which of the following are conditions or issues that we should be aware of as potential injury risks for young athletes?

- Osgood schlatters
- osteoporosis
- severs disease
- growth plate injuries
- arthritis

Here are the correct answers:

- Osgood schlatters
- severs disease
- growth plate injuries

These issues are most often related to overtraining of children and teenagers, who are still growing. They can't endure the stress that adult bones can, even when the cardiovascular and muscular strength may be pushing them forward.

COMMON CAUSES OF INJURY

Now we've taken a look at the common injuries in running, let's take a look at the possible causes.

- Poor footwear
- Poor running style
- Too much too soon - FIT Factors (Frequency. Intensity. Time.)
- Not strong enough for the demands of the activity
- Not enough rest between training
- Returning to running too soon after injury
- Not warmed up appropriately
- The environment/routes
    - Not being suitable for the age, or stage of development of the runner – too difficult / too demanding.

With so many injuries and causes, it's crucial you do as much as possible to try to prevent injury.

PREVENTING INJURIES

Okay, so what do you think you can do to prevent injury to runners?

Write down your answers.

Now compare your ideas to our suggestions. Please note that this list is not exhaustive.

- Refer runners to a shoe retail specialist who can conduct a gait analysis to help determine the best shoe type.
- Improve running style with games and tips.
- Work on one thing at a time.
- Ask Runners to keep a diary of how much training they're doing.
- Vary sessions to address all fitness elements.
- Keep sessions short and develop progressively.
- Need to adapt and recover following sessions as described in the FIT factors.
- Use fundamental movement activities to improve posture and control, for example, warm up.
- Maintain or improve flexibility by cooling down/stretching, taking part in other activities such as yoga, Pilates or swimming.
- Ensure you have risk assessed the route.
- When leading a session for 12-18 year olds you must always confirm the session content with a qualified coach for appropriateness to the age and stage of the runners.

Please go to the resources section to view more information concerning Fundamental Movement Skills development and the Home Country Coach Development pages.

PEOPLE WHO CAN HELP

Try your best to advise about injury avoidance, however, you shouldn't advise beyond your knowledge and qualifications. There are limits to your role and there are potential dangers if you go beyond it. Remember there are other people who can help, such as:

- Coaches
- Physiotherapists or sports massage therapists
- Shoe retailer specialists

Don't hesitate to consult these people for help and advice.

DEALING WITH INJURIES

Let's take a look at dealing with injuries.

Do you think the following statements are true or false?

- You should only treat an injured runner if you've been trained to.
- Ask someone who's been trained to treat injuries.
- Attend a first aid course so that you can treat minor injuries.
- Treat an injury even if you haven't been trained
- Ask a physiotherapist to treat injuries.
- Search on google for advice on how to treat someone and follow guidance
- For minor soft tissue injuries use the RICE method to treat.

Here are the correct answers:

- You should only treat an injured runner if you've been trained.
- Ask someone who's been trained to treat injuries.
- Attend a first aid course so that you can treat minor injuries.
- Ask a physiotherapist to treat injuries.
- Use the RICED method for injury treatment.

The key is to remember you're only to treat injuries if you've been trained to do so. Otherwise, seek help from someone who's been trained.

RICED METHOD

Are you familiar with the **RICED** method for treating soft tissue injuries?

Rest, **i**ce, **c**omfortable support, **e**levate and **d**iagnosis.

If a runner has injured their leg, foot or arm, then the following guidance can be given to the runner:

- **R**est the injured part. Assist them to sit or lie down and support the injured part in a comfortable position, raised if possible.
- **I**ce is to be applied to the injury to reduce pain and swelling. This maybe an icepack or frozen vegetables wrapped in a towel. This must not be left in place for longer than 10 minutes in every hour.
- **C**omfort is to be provided through support. Leave the ice pack in place (if possible) and secure with a bandage that covers the area, ensuring it's not too tight.
- **E**levate the injured part to minimise swelling and bruising. For a leg injury, elevate to just above the groin height, with the injured leg resting on something like a pillow or cushion. For an arm injury, elevate above the armpit with a supporting cushion.
- Diagnosis of the injury. Advise the runner to see a medical professional such as a doctor or physiotherapist.

Now that you've learnt about RICED, please seek advice from a trained professional if you are uncertain about any aspect of the RICED principle, or the nature of the injury.

CONGRATULATIONS

Congratulations! You have now finished completed this British Athletics module, Role of the Leader in Injury Avoidance.

You should now be able to:

- Identify common running injuries and their causes.
- Recognise the role a leader plays in injury avoidance and treating injuries.

Thank you.